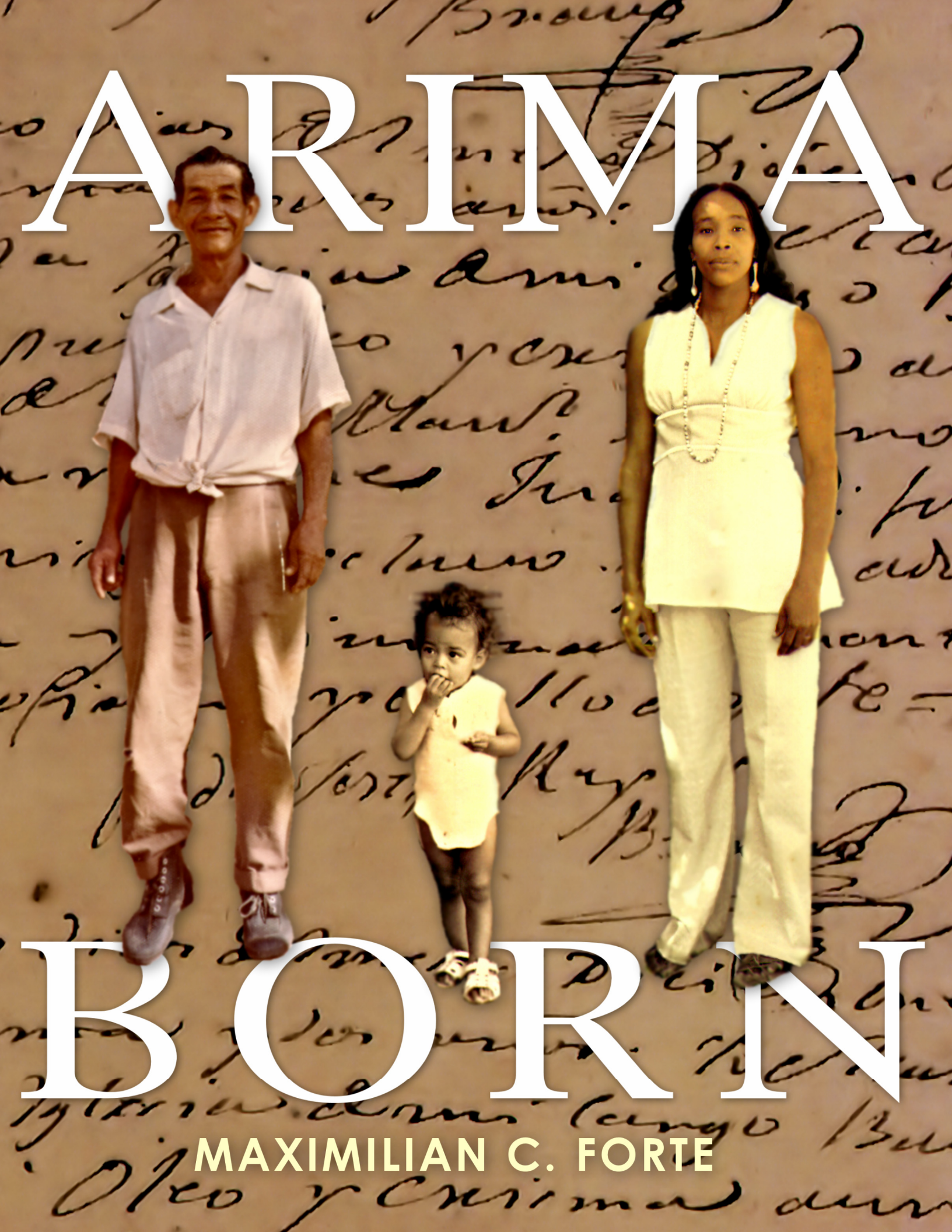




# ARIMA

# BORN

MAXIMILIAN C. FORTE

# ARIMA BORN

REVEALING THE HISTORY OF ARIMA AND ITS  
MISSION THROUGH THE CATHOLIC CHURCH'S  
BAPTISMAL REGISTERS, 1820-1916

*Maximilian C. Forte*



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# Contents

|                               |      |
|-------------------------------|------|
| <i>Illustrations</i> .....    | xi   |
| <i>Acknowledgements</i> ..... | xv   |
| <i>Preface</i> .....          | xvii |

## CHAPTER 1

|                                                                        |    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|
| <b>The Historical Context of the Arima Mission</b> .....               | 1  |
| Why Does Arima Matter?.....                                            | 1  |
| Power, Value, and Interests.....                                       | 4  |
| Land, Rights, and Identity.....                                        | 12 |
| Registering Identities.....                                            | 21 |
| In Dispute: Censuses and Tallies of Indians in Arima and Trinidad..... | 23 |
| Vanishing Acts: Switched Ethnicity and Dropped Ethnicity.....          | 31 |
| Resistance and Breakdown: The Secret Struggles with Assimilation.....  | 33 |
| A Critical Perspective on the Arima Mission.....                       | 39 |
| The Curious Case of Captain Sylvester and the Corregidor .....         | 41 |
| Prominent Members of the Carib Community in the Registers .....        | 44 |
| The Carib Queens .....                                                 | 45 |
| The Leading Families of the Santa Rosa Community .....                 | 56 |

## CHAPTER 2

### **By the Numbers: Reflections of the Demographic**

|                                                                        |    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|
| <b>History of Arima</b> .....                                          | 69 |
| What the Registers Tell Us about Arima, Mission Town.....              | 85 |
| On the History of the Church in Arima.....                             | 85 |
| On the Social History of Arima.....                                    | 87 |
| Indians, Caribs, Mestizos and the Notion of<br>Indigenous Decline..... | 89 |
| Africans in Arima .....                                                | 91 |
| Whites in Arima .....                                                  | 96 |



## CHAPTER 3

**Reading the Registers: Challenges and Guidelines..... 99**

|                                                                                     |     |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| Baptismal Registers and the History of Trinidad.....                                | 100 |
| A Detailed Analysis of Errors, Omissions, and Other Problems<br>with the Data ..... | 102 |
| Family Names and Ethnic Membership.....                                             | 110 |
| Guidelines for Understanding the Registers.....                                     | 111 |
| Background: Translation of Latin Guidelines for Recording Baptisms .....            | 113 |
| Background: List of Priests Serving in the Santa Rosa RC Church,<br>1749-1924.....  | 115 |
| Work Remaining to be Done.....                                                      | 117 |

## CHAPTER 4

**The Baptismal Registers ..... 119**

|                                                                                |     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| Select Records from the First Register of the Mission .....                    | 119 |
| Book One, Baptismal Register of Santa Rosa de Arima, 1820-1835.....            | 127 |
| Book Two, Baptismal Register of Santa Rosa de Arima, 1835-1852.....            | 185 |
| Select Entries for 1840-1852, Extracted from Book Two .....                    | 198 |
| “Mestizo” Entries for 1835-1852, Extracted from Book Two.....                  | 207 |
| Book Three, Baptismal Register of Santa Rosa de Arima, 1866-1876 .....         | 208 |
| Book Four, Baptismal Register of Santa Rosa de Arima, 1877-1887 .....          | 216 |
| Book Five, Baptismal Register of Santa Rosa de Arima, 1887-1892 .....          | 227 |
| Book Six, Baptismal Register of Santa Rosa de Arima, 1892-1899.....            | 240 |
| Book Seven, Baptismal Register of Santa Rosa de Arima, 1900-1906 .....         | 264 |
| Book Eight, Baptismal Register of Santa Rosa de Arima, 1906-1910 .....         | 272 |
| Books Nine & Ten, Baptismal Register of Santa Rosa de Arima,<br>1910-1916..... | 278 |

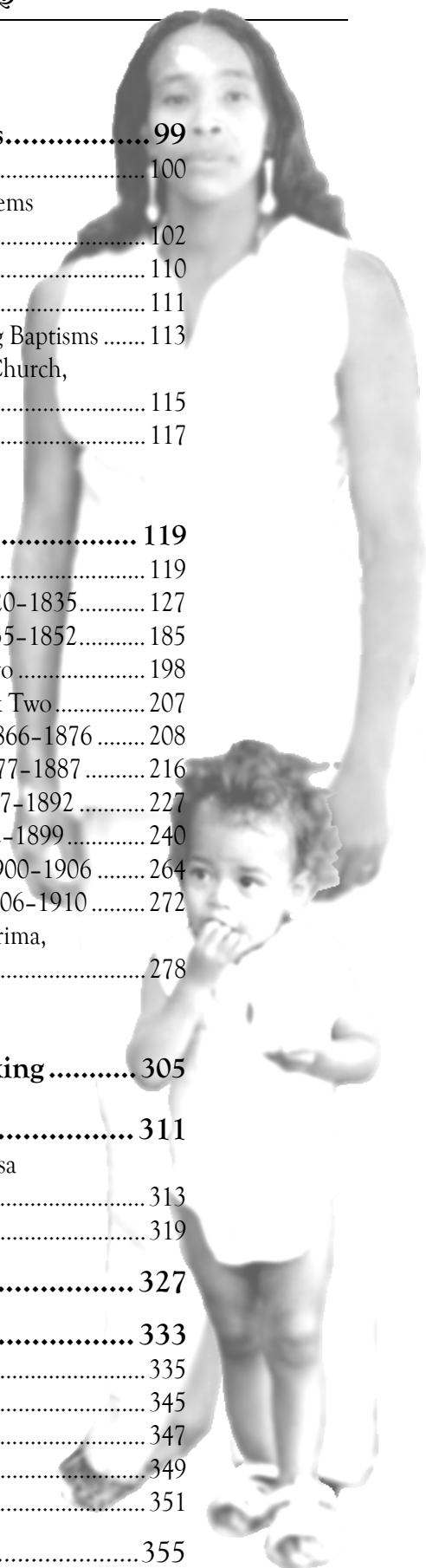
## CHAPTER 5

**Conclusions: The Collapse of Colonial Myth-Making..... 305****Appendices ..... 311**

|                                                                                                               |     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| Appendix A: Grave Markers—Information from the Santa Rosa<br>Roman Catholic Cemetery on King St., Arima ..... | 313 |
| Appendix B: Stray Documents .....                                                                             | 319 |

**Select Bibliography..... 327****Indices ..... 333**

|                                                              |     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| 1. Index of Named (Indigenous) Indians in the Registers..... | 335 |
| 2. Index of “Indians of this Mission” .....                  | 345 |
| 3. Index of Names with Tribal Designations.....              | 347 |
| 4. Index of Mestizos .....                                   | 349 |
| 5. General Index .....                                       | 351 |

**About the Author..... 355**

# Illustrations

## *Tables*

|                                                                                                    |     |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| Table 1: Trinidad Amerindian Population Statistics, 1782–1838 .....                                | 25  |
| Table 2: Baptism Statistics for Amerindians in Arima, 1820–1852.....                               | 29  |
| Table 3: Marriage Statistics for Amerindian Parents Baptising<br>Children in Arima, 1820–1852..... | 34  |
| Table 4: Baptisms, 1820–1835.....                                                                  | 73  |
| Table 5: Baptisms, 1835–1840.....                                                                  | 76  |
| Table 6: Baptisms, 1840–1916.....                                                                  | 77  |
| Table 7: Priests Who Served in the Santa Rosa RC Church.....                                       | 116 |

## *Figures*

|                                                                                |       |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|
| Figure I: Father David Oliveire .....                                          | xvii  |
| Figure II: Father Leo Donovan .....                                            | xviii |
| Figure 1: Slave of Manuel Sorzano, Arima Mission.....                          | 7     |
| Figure 2: Manuel Sorzano, Godfather to a Slave.....                            | 7     |
| Figure 3: Pardo Slave.....                                                     | 21    |
| Figure 4: Trinidad Population Statistics, 1782–1838.....                       | 27    |
| Figure 5: Amerindian Population Statistics, 1782–1838 .....                    | 28    |
| Figure 6: Counting Out the Indians, 1833.....                                  | 31    |
| Figure 7: Queen Maria Werges .....                                             | 47    |
| Figure 8: Queen Edith Martinez .....                                           | 48    |
| Figure 9: Velorio de la Cruz (Cross Wake) [3 Images].....                      | 52    |
| Figure 10: Scenes of the Santa Rosa Festival from the 1970s [3 Images] ....    | 54    |
| Figure 11: Santa Rosa Carib Community.....                                     | 57    |
| Figure 12: Calderon, Hernandez, Lopez Families.....                            | 60    |
| Figure 13: Clarisse/Clara Calderon.....                                        | 61    |
| Figure 14: Maria Nicolasa Calderon .....                                       | 62    |
| Figure 15: Evangelita Calderon .....                                           | 63    |
| Figure 16: Hyacinto Hernandez.....                                             | 64    |
| Figure 17: Manuelita Hernandez .....                                           | 64    |
| Figure 18: First Cousins of Manuelita Hernandez .....                          | 65    |
| Figure 19: Clemencia Hill-Assing .....                                         | 66    |
| Figure 20: “Pardos Libres” (Free Persons of African-Indian<br>Background)..... | 70    |
| Figure 21: Ethnic Distribution in Arima, 1820–1840.....                        | 79    |
| Figure 22: Ethnic Distribution in Arima, 1820–1835.....                        | 80    |
| Figure 23: Ethnic Distribution in Arima, 1835–1840.....                        | 80    |
| Figure 24: Spanish vs. East Indian Family Name Trends, 1840–1916.....          | 81    |

|                                                                                      |     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| Figure 25: “Indigenous Decline,” 1820–1852.....                                      | 82  |
| Figure 26: African Migrant.....                                                      | 85  |
| Figure 27: Slave of La Horqueta Estate.....                                          | 92  |
| Figure 28: Black Slaves in the Arima Mission [2 Images].....                         | 92  |
| Figure 29: “Persons of Colour” in the Arima Mission.....                             | 94  |
| Figure 30: Cecilia, Native of Africa, Apprentice.....                                | 95  |
| Figure 31: Grenadian Migrant.....                                                    | 96  |
| Figure 32: Nevisian Migrant.....                                                     | 96  |
| Figure 33: Whites in the Arima Mission.....                                          | 98  |
| Figure 34: Pages from the Earliest Registers of the<br>Arima Mission [7 Images]..... | 120 |
| Figure 35: Carib Indian in the Register.....                                         | 127 |
| Figure 36: Maria De Jesus Rosa, Indian.....                                          | 130 |
| Figure 37: Juan, Indian.....                                                         | 131 |
| Figure 38: Maria De La Cruz Reyes, Indian.....                                       | 131 |
| Figure 39: Indian from the Mainland.....                                             | 145 |
| Figure 40: Indian Godparents.....                                                    | 145 |
| Figure 41: Indian Godparents.....                                                    | 146 |
| Figure 42: Indian from the Mainland.....                                             | 165 |
| Figure 43: Juana Maria Medera, Mestiza.....                                          | 172 |
| Figure 44: Indian-Coloured from Oropuche.....                                        | 173 |
| Figure 45: Indian of this Mission.....                                               | 174 |
| Figure 46: Indian of this Mission.....                                               | 174 |
| Figure 47: Warao Indian from Pedernales.....                                         | 175 |
| Figure 48: “Coloured Carib” from Guanapo.....                                        | 177 |
| Figure 49: Andrea, “Indian”.....                                                     | 182 |
| Figure 50: Micaela De Los Santos Bencochea, “Indian”.....                            | 182 |
| Figure 51: Maria Juliana Sala, Indian.....                                           | 193 |
| Figure 52: Maria Josefa Reyes, Indian.....                                           | 202 |
| Figure 53: Henry Jose Delisle.....                                                   | 226 |
| Figure 54: Augustina Lopez.....                                                      | 232 |
| Figure 55: Father Charles De Martini.....                                            | 241 |
| Figure 56: Agatha Lucas.....                                                         | 255 |
| Figure 57: Saba and Camilla Lucas.....                                               | 256 |
| Figure 58: Margarita De Gazon.....                                                   | 269 |
| Figure 59: Clemencia Calderon.....                                                   | 274 |
| Figure 60: Leontine Hernandez-Fermin.....                                            | 276 |
| Figure 61: Alejandro (Alexander) Calderon, Copy of Baptismal Entry....               | 280 |
| Figure 62: Enrique Campo.....                                                        | 281 |
| Figure 63: Claudina Hernandez.....                                                   | 282 |
| Figure 64: Paulina Calderon.....                                                     | 283 |
| Figure 65: Millicent Campo.....                                                      | 285 |
| Figure 66: Rita Julia (Julie) Calderon.....                                          | 286 |
| Figure 67: Dionisio Peltación Calderon.....                                          | 287 |
| Figure 68: Peter De Ramos.....                                                       | 288 |

|                                                                  |     |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| Figure 69: Enemencio Hernandez .....                             | 292 |
| Figure 70: Alejandra Lopez .....                                 | 294 |
| Figure 71: Damasia Cardines.....                                 | 303 |
| Figure 72: Luce Anne Sellier.....                                | 315 |
| Figure 73: Father Edmund J. Dillon.....                          | 316 |
| Figure 74: Celestina Lucas .....                                 | 317 |
| Figure 75: Loose Sheet from the Baptismal Register, Side 1 ..... | 320 |
| Figure 76: Loose Sheet from the Baptismal Register, Side 2 ..... | 321 |
| Figure 77: Baptismal Certificate .....                           | 322 |
| Figure 78: Notes on a Scrap of Paper, Side 1 .....               | 323 |
| Figure 79: Notes on a Scrap of Paper, Side 2 .....               | 324 |
| Figure 80: Envelope Mailed to Arima RC Priest.....               | 325 |
| Figure 81: Letter to Arima RC Priest.....                        | 326 |



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Many thanks are due to Father Leo Donovan, the former parish priest of the Santa Rosa RC Church, for facilitating generous access to the Baptismal Registers of Arima for the 19<sup>th</sup>- and early-20<sup>th</sup> centuries. I am also grateful for the advice, recommendations, and guidance of the late Father David Oliveire, who was previously based in Arima, and from whom the very idea for this project originally came. My father, Enrico Mario Forte, provided me with extensive translations from the original Latin of a number of notes and entries in the earliest baptismal registers; his knowledge of antiquated church practices for labelling orphaned children were among some of the very useful details he shared with me; and, thanks also for his keen eye in spotting a letter to the Santa Rosa RC parish priest at a table at a distant philatelic convention, an envelope which he kindly purchased for me, and which is reproduced here in an appendix. Ricardo Bharath Hernandez, Chief of the Santa Rosa First People's Community, afforded generous access to his photographic archives and shared his detailed knowledge on the family histories of members of the community. Many librarians at the National Library and Information System of Trinidad and Tobago (NALIS), at the University of the West Indies, St. Augustine, and at the Arima Public Library, deserve more thanks than I can express. As always, I owe especial thanks to my wife, Allison, who has followed me closely in this endeavour and sustained me in more ways than I could ever list here.

# Preface

ORIGINALLY, THE VERY IDEA of studying baptismal registers—which at first struck me as unusually esoteric—was the result of recommendations made to me by the late Father David Oliveire in early 1998. I strongly doubt that I would have thought of this area of research on my own, or early enough. In fact, I was originally resistant: “I am doing an ethnography of the present Community, not a history,” I told him during our talk after lunch. Thankfully, he persisted and thus overcame my rather unintelligent hesitations. Father David Oliveire served for a time in the Roman Catholic Church in Malabar, Arima, and was personally familiar with the contents of the baptismal registers in the Santa Rosa RC Church—he remarked he had seen how during the time of the Mission priests regularly inserted the word “Indian” next to entries for baptised children. He thought it would be a good way for me to get further background on the size of the Indigenous Amerindian community, and even the identities of the individuals who made up the community. In addition, Father Oliveire recommended Vincent Leahy’s *Catholic Church in Trinidad, 1797–1820*, a church historian’s research published in Arima itself—and if I am not mistaken, the copy I have was given to me by Father Oliveire. Thanks to Father Oliveire’s recommendations, I became a researcher in ethnohistory; it was a field I had studied, but not a direction that I had planned to take. I also have to say that it was thanks to coupling archival and historical research with my ethnographic fieldwork, that I had to double the amount of time and expense spent in Arima, which also required the consent of my Department at the University of Adelaide, Australia, where I earned my doctorate.



Figure 1:  
Father David Oliveire

Father Oliveire, whom I also knew as *Uncle David* because he was my wife’s maternal uncle, was also the priest who married us in the church in St. Joseph. David Oliveire was an especially important, influential, and profound presence in the family and among all of those who had the privilege to know him. He was a

man of exceptional wisdom, artistry, insight, and was always calm and open about entertaining any challenging discussions, unafraid to tangle with ideas which were contrary to his own. Uncle David was one of those persons one meets in life that reminds you how some of the best anthropologists in the world are “out there,” not in academia—they are not recognized as anthropologists even if they have a depth of vision and the finest sensitivity for intimate detail that rivals the best work we find in anthropology. His recommendation alone—not that of a supervisory committee at a university—is ultimately what led to this book. Something tells me he knew what I would find, and that it would shake my ironclad preconceptions. It is also still easy to remember, even to still hear, his deeply sonorous voice and to recall the pearls of advice which he offered. It is with genuine gratitude and humility that this work is dedicated to his memory.

Father Leo Donovan, who was the parish priest of the Santa Rosa RC Church during the period of my research from 1998 through 1999, and again from late 2001 through 2003, was particularly helpful in allowing me access to the baptismal registers for an extended period of time. While I am sure I overstayed my welcome, in the end it was good that I took as much time as I did, considering the apparent fact that the registers can no longer be located. I think that it was in Father Donovan’s time that the registers were sent to the Archives of the Archbishop’s Residence, to which subsequent researchers have turned, in vain. This is an issue of serious importance, and I strongly recommend that all of the relevant authorities take urgent action: this is the personal information that belongs, by right, to many thousands of Trinidadians. The registers are not only material evidence concerning the history of the Amerindians in the Arima Mission, they are also a detailed repository of data on African slaves in Arima and environs. In a period when reparations are being studied and proposed at the highest political levels across the Caribbean, such data must not be mislaid and forgotten.

Research that produced this book was conducted from 1998 through 1999, using the baptismal registers which were then housed in the Santa Rosa Roman Catholic Church of Arima. Additional documents, mostly notes and letters from parish priests of Arima from the 1800s, were sourced from the archives of the Roman Catholic Archbishop’s Residence in Port of Spain. In 2003, some final work was done in the Santa Rosa RC cemetery, recording names on tombstones in the hopes of finding some closure for the life histories traced out in this



Figure II:  
Father Leo Donovan

document—I am still thankful for the assistance of Cristo Adonis in that research, and for lightening the mood during what could have otherwise been one of the more depressing aspects of my research. The chief of the Carib Community, Ricardo Bharath Hernandez, was especially generous and patient in not only allowing me access to his photographic archive of members of the Carib Community of past generations, but also allowing me to digitize the images, and then taking me through each photograph by sharing a short biography and family history of each person shown. In addition, historical texts from the 1800s housed in the West Indiana section of the Main Library at the University of the West Indies, St. Augustine, plus numerous reels of microfilmed Trinidadian newspapers from the 1800s, were also a vital source of information.<sup>1</sup> I am thankful for the assistance of numerous librarians at UWI, at the NALIS main library in Port of Spain, at the Arima Public Library, plus the photographs division of the National Archives of Trinidad and Tobago, and the displays at the National Museum of Trinidad and Tobago. Recently, thanks to the digitization efforts of numerous universities in the US, Canada, and the UK, another batch of historical and other texts on Trinidad from the 1800s—many of which I had not even seen listed in bibliographies—have been released for public access through the Internet Archive and the Hathi Trust. These have been something of a treasure trove of “new” information (meaning quite old, but previously inaccessible). In fact, the newly released materials have compelled me to revise a number of my earlier assumptions and explanations. The process of revising my thinking, which was essential to producing the book in its current form, also benefited from proceeding very slowly.

It was 20 years ago that I committed to sharing the information contained in this book with members of the Santa Rosa Carib Community, and I must say they have been extremely patient. (Patient, yet persistent: what was ultimately at stake in this project was the *repatriation* of information on the personal family histories of many Trinidadian citizens.) We have all aged significantly as this project inched its way towards completion. Many community members have passed away in the meantime. Personal circumstances at one point threatened the loss of the information contained in this book not just for the community, but for all readers. There were delays for many reasons besides competing work obligations and personal difficulties: attempts to produce a statistical database and automated system using genealogical software were not only unsuccessful, they were a tremendous waste of time, and now the software itself is abundantly outdated. The

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<sup>1</sup> In the West Indiana section of UWI's Library, the following microfilms of the Colonial Records Office were examined, focusing on the first decades of British rule in Trinidad, when the Arima Mission was in existence: *Original Correspondence* (CO 295); *Entry Books* (CO 296); *Acts* (CO 297); *Sessional Papers* (CO 298); *Government Gazettes* (CO 299); *Miscellanea* (CO 300); *Miscellaneous Blue Books of Statistics* (CO 300); *Register of Correspondence* (CO 372); *Registers of Out Letters* (CO 497); *Supplementary Correspondence* (CO 537); and, *Correspondence Indexes* (CO 714). Specific microfilm reels pertaining to each of the files just listed will appear in subsequent references as, for example, “CO 295, 5,” meaning reel 5 of CO 295.

original idea was to have a searchable online database—that may still be possible, but it is beyond my technical abilities. I have had queries from many, *many* individuals over the years, asking me for information to verify or add to their knowledge of their family history, and until now I have not been able to satisfy their requests (in most cases). With the passage of 20 years, I have lost track of many of the e-mails that contained requests for information, and to which I had promised responses—to them I offer my sincere apologies.

My primary interest in conducting this particular research was to acquire a database of the names of as many Amerindians in the Mission of Arima as possible, with a view to understanding demographic changes. Secondly, it was to provide the then current members of the Santa Rosa Carib Community with some information about Indigenous history in Arima. I also traced some of the main family names of those persons I knew, which was not everyone in the community at the time, and thus it does not include those Arimians who joined or re-joined the Carib Community after the end of my fieldwork. The transcribed entries from the baptismal registers are thus nowhere near *all* of the entries which I examined—in fact, they constitute just a small fraction of the total. My focus was just on Amerindians, Mestizos, and all persons who might conceivably be related to members of the Carib Community as I then knew it. That is actually a fairly broad grasp, but nowhere near total. My own selectivity is another reason why the baptismal registers must be recovered—too much information of interest and relevance to all Arimians will be lost, including their personal family’s information.

The delays in producing this work, lasting a total of 20 years, may well have been propitious. With the passage of time, and more information, I have acquired a substantially different understanding of the history of the Arima Mission. It is different in the sense of having both more information, but also a broader and more nuanced understanding of the patterns we see in the registers. Now a distinctive pattern has taken shape. As a result, previous assumptions and explanations have been revised, and readers will therefore not be getting a plain and straight reiteration of my past work here. Indeed, there are quite a few “surprises,” and what seemed like certainties in the past are now revealed to be mythical constructs. Those readers who are anxious to find out what is new about this research, in contrast with my past work, can examine the Conclusions chapter—but they will spoil the process of how we got there, which was through many empirical and analytical steps taken in the chapters preceding the Conclusions.

Lastly, it was imperative that I make available a complete copy of all the material I had recorded from my research of the baptismal registers, so that it would be available to the broader public. Of course, the publication of such an amount of “raw data” would make this book unappealing to most/all cost-conscious academic publishers. Special attention was devoted to ensuring that none of the entries transcribed from the baptismal registers contained any errors, meaning that they

remained true to the original. However, as this book neared completion I discovered two more entries buried in my files, which I had neglected to transcribe before, and which did not figure in the tabulations of data shown in this book. The originals transcribed by priests may (and often did) contain errors—and this work preserves and, unfortunately by necessity, perpetuates those errors. The latter is the primary reason for the extensive chapters that contextualize and sometimes correct the data. Any errors in the analysis of the material are of course my responsibility alone.



# Conclusions: *The Collapse of Colonial Myth-Making*

**C**ELEBRATING ARIMA'S MISSION HISTORY might be as unwise or at least as insensitive as celebrating the history of a slave plantation, or celebrating the history of a prison. The Arima Mission was a scheme designed to benefit very powerful and wealthy estate owners and ecclesiastical authorities. Rewarding one of his stalwart allies just before the British arrived, Governor Chacón granted Manuel Sorzano the right to establish the Mission and acquire the labour of several hundred Amerindians. He already owned the African slaves which he exploited on his estate, and now he had the right to command the labour of additional fieldhands, who would also dig roads for him to access markets, supply men to staff his armed militia, and cultivate cassava to feed his slaves. The Church also directly profited from the Amerindian labour force, both from the cocoa which the Amerindians cultivated, but also from the proceeds of sales of rum to the Amerindians. And, if some of the worst accusations were true, specific clerics also availed themselves of the bodies of young Amerindian girls.

It is absolutely vital that we understand that Trinidad's colonial authorities represented the interests of capital, dedicated to the extraction of surplus. The whole purpose of the colony was to generate wealth for interests in the "mother country," and for privileged local potentates who facilitated the outflow. When Amerindian labour was valuable, the amount of land freely available to it was restricted, precisely by confining them to a Mission with a clearly delimited land area. When the lands cultivated by Amerindians (specifically those producing cocoa) became of value greater than the labour of the Amerindians (because of

increased cocoa prices, rising land prices, and new arrivals of labour), then it was the labour of Amerindians that became disposable. In order to maximize the availability of land in and around Arima, authorities had to minimize the Trinidad Amerindian population. Thus the creation of the Mission, and its dissolution, are simply mirror images of each other. Colonial authorities created poverty out of what was plenty for the majority of the so-called “free” labourers, in order to create excessive wealth for the very few who were already wealthy. There are, in the end, no heroes here—there was no actual “protector” of the Indians, and certainly neither Chacón nor Woodford.

Among the many things that we learned from studying the baptismal registers of the Arima Mission, are that certain myths (working fictions) have been in operation and, like all good myths, they are contradicted by documentary evidence. The primary myths include the following:

1. The myth of the Mission as a form of racial segregation and exclusion;
2. The myth of protection of the Amerindians by the authorities;
3. The myth of the vanishing Amerindians; and,
4. The myth of succesful assimilation and Christian indoctrination.

The Mission as an *Indian Mission* is a myth—this depiction is concretely and completely contradicted by the baptismal registers themselves. The notion that the Mission was created solely or even partly for the purpose of segregating and preserving Amerindians and protecting their rights, is empirically false. The Mission’s baptismal registers themselves provide ample evidence of an abundance of African slaves baptised by the missionary and belonging to the founder of the Mission. Arima, if we were to be fair, could be defined as primarily a *slave colony*. Rather than creating the conditions for the perpetuation of Amerindians as a social unit, it seems everything was done in the Mission to achieve their dissipation when it became convenient. Membership in the Mission was based on adherence to strict categories of racial belonging—any deviation, by having children with members of other groups, resulted in a nullification of the contract between the Mission and its inhabitants. Within the same Mission were even larger numbers of African slaves, free Blacks, Spaniards, French, and English families, which facilitated the very miscegenation that disqualified persons from laying any claim to lands in Arima. Thus Ricardo Bharath Hernandez was quite justified in pointing out the following, as he did to me in 1995:

“The fact is that the People here in Trinidad who comprise the community—the Santa Rosa Carib Community—are not pure in the sense of blood because it is mixed. The Carib tribe, the Carib people mixed with the different ethnic groups so you would find Caribs for instance, mixed with Chinese, mixed with African, mixed with East Indian and whatever ethnic group that you might find here in Trinidad. *And we say it is not our fault.* The people

who survived today and still identify with the tradition of the original people—if you would want to call it that—it is *not our fault that we are mixed*". (emphases added)

At first, I was struck by Ricardo's choice of words, "it is not our fault that we are mixed". Whose "fault" was it? I did not realize at the time just how correct his statement was, on many levels. What is being criticized here is not miscegenation, but rather the authorities who created the perfect conditions for it to happen and then turned around and delegitimized the results of miscegenation with the arbitrary impositions of their racial order, ultimately designed to produce a transfer of capital, which in turn resulted in the creation of poverty. It is important to recall the basic principle at work throughout all of this: *the creation of poverty out of plenty, for the benefit of a few*.

Far from offering the Amerindians "protection," the Mission was an engine of their socio-economic demise. Some Amerindians, suffering from the depression and distress of life in the Mission, apparently drank themselves into poverty and debt, and then sold off their individual plots. Yet it was the Mission itself which furnished them with the rum, having an exclusive monopoly on its sale within Arima. In addition, alcohol-fueled indebtedness ensured a transfer of capital from the Amerindians to the Mission: "The expenses of the Arima mission were defrayed from the profits of a liquor store at the settlement" (Wood, 1968, p. 44). The authorities, both under the last Spanish governor and the first British governors, also sold off pieces of Amerindian lands in Arima.

When the value of Amerindian-held lands exceeded the value of their labour, the Amerindians became an inconvenience. To better facilitate and justify the Amerindians' "exit" from Arima, the authorities literally counted them out: they vanished from the censuses, and those who had been marked as Indian in the baptismal registers reappeared without any such label attached to their names.

Thus another myth was born: that the Amerindians became "extinct". The prevailing counts of Amerindians in the Arima Mission are questionable for a variety of reasons, chief of which was the authorities' interest in restricting and then cancelling membership in the Indian ethnic category as time progressed. One source that cited the *Trinidad Almanac* for 1824, reported that a population of 278 Indians in the Arima Mission included 141 children—men, 60; women, 77; boys, 81; girls, 60 (Coleridge, 1826, p. 82). De Verteuil suggested the Amerindians had a "3.75% birth rate" in 1830, which in modern terms would be 37.5 births per 1,000 persons—a fairly high birth rate (1858, p. 172).<sup>137</sup> Dealing with the total Amerindian

<sup>137</sup> If De Verteuil's 3.75% birth rate was correct—and it seems convincing, as it resembles Trinidad and Tobago's birth rate in 1960—then we should have expected his reported Amerindian population total of 689 persons to *double* in 18.66 years (that is, by 1848), following the Rule of 70. Instead he stated that the total fell to 200–300 persons by the 1850s, even though the birth rate *exceeded* the 3.49% death rate he reported

population in Trinidad in 1797, numerous sources report on a survey that counted 1,082 Amerindians—men, 305; women, 401; boys, 190; girls, 186 (M'Callum, 1805, p. 32)—this number sits well with De Verteuil's birth rate figure.

Based on numbers from the registers (192 Amerindian children baptised from 1820 to 1835), and then comparing them with the two sets of numbers above, and the birth rate mentioned by De Verteuil, gives us three possible numbers: 341, 376, and 552 persons as the total population needed to produce those 192 children (which averages at 12.8 children per year). The average of all three estimated totals is 423 persons. However, one problem with that method (crude as it is), is that it does not take into account Indian parents who, in "mixed" unions, produced children marked as either Mestizo or Pardo. In the period 1820–1835, there appear to be 13 children baptised and labelled as Mestizo, and in none of the cases is either parent identified as Indian (usually the parents in these cases were not assigned any racial label by the priest). Another method is to take those same 192 children, and add two parents for each child, and then add two godparents—which gives us a maximum number of 960 persons *over 15 years*. That includes the repeat appearances of parents and godparents, thus 900 persons would be the safer number. However, as that number covers a range of years, we would need to take into account that some would have died or left the Mission. A range of 400 to 800 persons seems like a safe bet, one that takes into account the fact that Indian parents were counted out when their children were Mestizo or Pardo. We have no way of knowing how many baptised children were *not* entered into the registers.

What makes the registers so striking is that when we take into account the fact that the Arima Mission had about 50% of all of Trinidad's Amerindians, then what stands out is the undercount on the *colony-wide* level. In 1831, 762 Amerindians were reported to exist in all of Trinidad—a number that seems terribly doubtful when we see that figure is reached, or even exceeded, just by the number of Arima Mission residents alone. One of the other benefits of this project was that it allowed me to revise and update comprehensive tables of Amerindian population numbers.

Ultimately, the most striking feature of the baptismal registers is how Amerindians were made to vanish—this is a point that is even more important than actual numbers. Their presence in the registers was constructed by the labelling practices of the priests; likewise, their "disappearance" was effected by simply ceasing to use a specific label. The Amerindians did not *vanish*, as such: they were *vanished*. One census refused to count Indians because they were deemed not to be inhabitants, a crude irony at best.

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(1858, p. 172). In other words, the drop would have been *naturally* impossible. At worst, the population size should have been relatively stable. His opinion for the alleged fall is, strictly speaking, a racist one: they had "finally sunk under the ascendancy of a more intelligent race"—and because the argument lacks scientific credibility, then so does his assertion of there being only 200–300 Indian persons.

Another pattern we witness in the baptismal registers is that of *Indigenous substitution*—the result of large numbers of Venezuelan migrants entering the Arima district. Most of the members of the Carib Community as I knew it, had roots that could easily be traced to the post-1870s wave of Venezuelan arrivals. What we do not see in the baptismal registers is any clear and direct continuity from the Indians of the Arima Mission, when it formally existed as such, and the current Carib/First People’s Community. This entails an even *stronger* version of Indigenous resurgence than I originally understood and discussed in earlier publications. A softer form of resurgence is where continuity exists, and thus what is revitalized is an already existing base in a community of persons with established traditions. It takes far more work to increase from a situation of discontinuity and displacement. A new community, that with time was identified by the surrounding society as “Carib,” was one that had been built by new arrivals who had a cultural, religious, and even ethnic affinity with those who previously occupied the area of the Mission and who had been displaced to surrounding regions. Members of the two groups, the ex-Mission residents and Venezuelan migrants, would have likely encountered each other in surrounding districts and inter-married. Those encounters would have probably been found in the registers that came after those which were accessed for this project—which is one more area where work remains to be done.

A related myth is that the Amerindians were genuinely devout converts to Christianity who did not resist the “civilizing mission”. The baptismal registers themselves contain many subtle signs of resistance, of limits to the civilizing mission of Christian assimilation. One of the tell-tale clues is the fact that the majority of children were born out of wedlock, sometimes to parents who themselves had multiple partners. When coupled with contextualizing data from other primary sources of the time—reports on education in the colony, travellers’ accounts of their encounters with “wild” Indian families in the forests, a corregidor’s memoir of a fierce Amerindian shaman ruling over the Indians of northern Trinidad, a governor’s injunctions against Amerindians burying their dead in forests, authorities’ explicit concerns over the failure to properly teach Amerindians the Christian way of life, and so forth—we then have the basis for a more robust and nuanced understanding of the cultural processes that accompanied the break-up of the Arima Mission. Even the supposed “decline” of the Santa Rosa Festival can be reinterpreted as a festival that came into greater alignment with Amerindian preferences, *instead* of or *against* Catholic preferences. The end results are questions that only readers can answer for themselves, and that is whether the creation of the Arima Mission was something worthy of praise, and whether its dissolution is ultimately something that warrants lament.

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